

SOP 104: Incidental Findings

1 Summary

On rare occasions MRI research personnel may identify neurologic idiosyncracies, termed an ‘incidental finding’, in data collected at the Notre Dame Human Neuroimaging Center (ND-HNC). This document establishes procedures for responding to such incidental findings.

2 Scope

These policies apply to all investigators, research assistants, and staff who collect, review, or use MRI data collected the ND-HNC.

3 Definitions

- **IRB:** Institutional Review Board, an independent committee that reviews and approves research involving human subjects to protect their rights, safety, and welfare.
- **Operator:** MRI Technologist or Level 4 researcher, responsible for conducting research operations and maintaining equipment. The Lead during emergency responses.

4 Policies & Procedures

The ND-HNC operates primarily as a research facility focused on executing experimental MRI protocols, meaning that collected datasets are not routinely reviewed by a clinician. Given the volume of scans processed at the facility, however, research personnel will occasionally encounter idiosyncratic or anomalous anatomy.

Encountering such idiosyncracies introduces a number of responsibilities which the researcher must navigate to fulfill ethical and legal obligations. Namely, research personnel:

- do not normally use diagnostic MRI protocols nor hold the necessary qualifications to make medical diagnoses,
- may not cause harm to participants (e.g. undue stress, unnecessary medical expenses),
- must protect participant anonymity,
- must adhere to IRB regulations of data usage and governance, and
- ought to consult with qualified individuals in case the anomalous image is medically significant.

To help research personnel navigate these obligations, we provide an escalation protocol which is to be followed whenever research personnel suspect that collected MRI data has identified medically relevant anomalies. A description of these procedures should be included in any IRB application involving use of the ND-HNC MRI scanner.

4.1 Initial Review

All MRI data collected at the ND-HNC should be reviewed by their respective research team. This typically happens during acquisition but may also occur on research equipment.

- If the individual is still in the bore of the magnet, the Operator should acquire an axial T2-weighted series.
- Research personnel should **NOT** share their concerns with the individual who contributed MRI data.
- The principal investigator (PI) should be contacted about the incidental finding. It is the responsibility of the PI to coordinate with ND-HNC staff for External Review and with the participant for any potential Follow-Up.

4.2 External Review

4.3 Follow-Up

5 Figures

None.